

Chapter 20

The Release Plan

The following steps are necessary in order to create the release plan:

1. Select an iteration length.
2. Estimate the velocity.
3. Prioritize the stories.
4. Allocate stories to the one or more iterations.

Because the new website features need to be available in four weeks, the team decides to use two-week iterations. This will give them the opportunity to run two iterations before the deadline. They'll prioritize the highest priority features into the first iteration to make sure those are completed. After the first iteration they will be able to assess their velocity and decide how much work they can bring into the second iteration.

Estimating Velocity

Maria and Rafe are will be the programmers on the project. Jay helped estimate but other commitments prevent him from helping develop the website. Since the project is unlike prior websites that the programmers have developed, they cannot estimate a velocity for the new project by basing it on the velocity of a prior project. So, they'll need to take an educated guess.

When they estimated the stories, Maria and Rafe loosely defined one story point as one ideal day of programming. They now decide that it will take them between two and three real days to do one ideal day worth of work. With two-week (ten-day) iterations and two programmers, there will be twenty programmer-days per iteration. Maria and Rafe estimate that they'll be able to complete between seven and ten story points during each iteration. Deciding to be conservative for the first iteration, they estimate velocity at eight.

Prioritizing the Stories

Lori the customer prioritizes the stories. The main factor in determining the priority of a story is the value it will deliver to the business. However, Lori also needs to consider the estimate for the story. Occasionally, highly desired stories become less desirable when their cost (the estimates) are considered.

To start prioritizing, Lori sorts the story cards into four piles based on their importance to the targeted go-live date in four weeks: Must Have, Should Have, Could Have, and Won't Have. Lori's Must-Have stories are shown in Table 20.1.

Table 20.1 *The Must-Have stories for the initial release in four weeks.*

Story	Estimate
A user can do a basic simple search that searches for a word or phrase in both the author and title fields.	1
A user can put books into a “shopping cart” and buy them when she is done shopping.	1
A user can remove books from her cart before completing an order.	½
To buy a book the user enters her billing address, the shipping address and credit card information.	2
A user can establish an account that remembers shipping and billing information.	2
Orders made on the website have to end up in the same order database as telephone orders.	0
An administrator can add new books to the site.	1
An administrator can delete a book.	½
An administrator can edit the information about an existing book.	1
The system must support peak usage of up to 50 concurrent users.	0

The sum of the estimates for Lori's must-have stories is nine. Since velocity is estimated at eight per iteration and there will be two iterations, this leaves room to dip into some of Lori's should-have stories. Lori pulls the stories shown in Table 20.2 from her pile of should-have stories. Between her must-have and should-have stories she's now identified 15½ points, which is close enough to

the sixteen points the programmers think they can complete over two iterations.

Table 20.2 *The Should-Have stories Lori adds to the release plan.*

Story	Estimate
A user can search for books by entering values in any combination of author, title and ISBN.	1
A user can edit the credit card information stored in her account.	½
A user can edit the shipping and billing addresses stored in her account.	1
A user can see what books we recommend on a variety of topics.	4

The Finished Release Plan

The finished release plan is put together as shown in Table 20.3 and is communicated to the rest of the organization that way. Maria and Rafe will do their best to complete the work planned for the first iteration. If they do well, they'll work with Lori to move a new story or two up into the first iteration. If they get behind, they'll work with Lori to move a story or two from the first iteration to the second.

Table 20.3 *The finished release plan.*

Iteration 1	Iteration 2
A user can do a basic simple search that searches for a word or phrase in both the author and title fields.	An administrator can edit the information about an existing book.
A user can put books into a “shopping cart” and buy them when she is done shopping.	A user can search for books by entering values in any combination of author, title and ISBN.
A user can remove books from her cart before completing an order.	A user can edit the credit card information stored in her account.
To buy a book the user enters her billing address, the shipping address and credit card information.	A user can edit the shipping and billing addresses stored in her account.
Orders made on the website have to end up in the same order database as telephone orders.	A user can see what books we recommend on a variety of topics.

Table 20.3 *The finished release plan. (Continued)*

Iteration 1	Iteration 2
A user can establish an account that remembers shipping and billing information.	
An administrator can add new books to the site.	
An administrator can delete a book.	
The system must support peak usage of up to 50 concurrent users.	